



Theater

Madeleine Béjart was the leading lady of the theatrical company managed by Molière, the genius of French comedy whose plays entertained Louis and his court.

Palace of Versailles

Once established at Versailles, Louis' court became a magnet for all the talent in France, and a monument to French cultural and political prestige.

styled by artists paid to glorify him. And, like the sun god Apollo, Louis wished to appear a great patron of the arts, provided that the artists obeyed the various controls imposed by the royal academies. At the heart of the royal palace, which at its height was the size of a small town containing upwards of 10,000 people, were the apartments of Louis, his Spanish

Queen, Marie Thérèse, and the

royal mistress. It was usual for the current royal mistress to enjoy court honors, and the children resulting from the relationships were acknowledged by the king.

The Sun King died at the age of 77, in the 56th year of his personal rule. His final years were clouded by bereavement, military defeat, and a catastrophic country-wide collapse in the French economy. The sudden deaths of his son,

the dauphin (heir apparent), his grandson, and his elder great-grandson—all within a matter of months—meant that his kingdom passed to his five-year-old great grandson, Louis XV.



Sun motif

This gilded sun emblem made of carved wood is found on the walls of the palace of Versailles. Sun motifs served as logos for Louis XIV's golden reign.

industry under state control, and did what he could to boost French naval power. He was also in charge of the royal household's finances, a responsibility that included the cost of Versailles.

The court of the Sun King

Versailles began as a modest hunting lodge near Paris, where the young Louis XIV entertained his intimate friends. In the late 1660s Louis started to devote more attention to the project of reconstructing and extending the old hunting lodge into

a royal palace. There was method behind Louis' extravagant plan to build a great royal palace. By making Versailles the permanent base of the royal court and the seat of government from 1682, Louis created a hugely attractive nexus of power and influence, which the nobility found irresistible, and which persuaded them to trade provincial power for influence and rewards at Court, under the direct auspices of the king. Above all, the Court was a center of conspicuous consumption and magnificence, principally intended to glorify the "Sun King," as Louis was

TIMELINE

- **1638** Birth of Louis, long awaited first-born child of Anne of Austria and Louis XIII of France.
- **1643** Death of Louis XIII; Anne of Austria and chief minister Cardinal Mazarin effectively rule France.
- **1648–53** The period of internal troubles and civil war in France known as the Fronde.
- **1648** Treaty of Westphalia brings to an end the Thirty Years War (see pp.262–63).
- **1659** Treaty of Pyrenees brings peace with Spain, cemented by a proposed marriage alliance between Louis XIV and the Spanish princess, Marie Thérèse.
- **June 9, 1660** Marriage to Marie Thérèse of Spain.
- **1661** Death of Cardinal Mazarin; Louise de la Vallière becomes the official royal mistress; Louis begins his personal rule; birth of Louis' eldest son, the dauphin Louis.
- **1666** Death of Anne of Austria.
- **1667** Louis XIV establishes the French Academy of Science.
- **1668** Treaty of Aix-La-Chapelle marks France's successful annexation of part of the Spanish Netherlands.
- **1672–78** France goes to war against the Dutch.
- **1682** The full court moves to the new palace of Versailles, 12 miles (19 km) west of Paris; birth of Louis' first grandson, the Duc de Bourgogne.
- **1683** After the death of his wife, Louis XIV marries his long-term companion Madame de Maintenon in a secret ceremony.
- **1685** Louis XIV revokes the Edict of Nantes, ending the freedom to worship of French Protestants (Huguenots), hundreds of thousands of whom leave France; the indignation of Europe's Protestant powers, Holland, England, and Sweden contributes to the formation of the Grand Alliance against France.
- **1689** William of Orange, now also king of England, leads the Grand Alliance against France.
- **1700** Charles II of Spain (half-brother of Louis' queen, Marie Thérèse) dies without heirs. His bequeaths the throne in the first instance to Louis XIV's grandson, the Duc d'Anjou, who becomes Philip V of Spain.
- **1701–13** War of the Spanish Succession is triggered by counter-claims to the Spanish throne by Holy Roman Emperor Leopold I and Louis' expansionist policies. The war ends in 1713 at the Treaty of Utrecht, with Philip V left on the Spanish throne, but the Spanish Empire partitioned.
- **1711–12** Deaths of Louis XIV's eldest son (the dauphin), grandson (the Duc de Bourgogne), and elder great-grandson.
- **1715** Louis XIV dies at Versailles; he is succeeded by his only surviving legitimate descendant, his great-grandson, who becomes Louis XV.



LOUIS XIV'S MARRIAGE

IDEA

ABSOLUTE MONARCHY

From the moment of his coronation (pictured, right) Louis XIV demonstrated his belief that he had a "divine right"—God-given duty—to rule France as an absolute monarch, without consulting parliaments, ministers, or senior nobles. Blessed with stamina, confidence, and a passion for order, he was an extraordinarily capable ruler. Even when he was at war, he insisted on daily progress reports about the construction of Versailles. Other monarchs envied his power and his palace; the scale of the palace of Versailles was mimicked all over Europe.

